Rongjie Zhang

Research Fellow · MIT Center for Real Estate · Massachusetts Institute of Technology

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Academic Appointments

2026–present Research Fellow, MIT Center for Real Estate, Massachusetts Institute of Technology

2024–2026 Research Fellow, Institute of Real Estate and Urban Studies, National University of Singapore

Education

2024 Ph.D. in Engineering, Department of Civil Engineering, Tsinghua University

Outstanding Ph.D. Dissertation (top 5%); Excellent Graduate Award (top 1%); Rising Academic Star Award.

2019 Bachelor of Engineering, Department of Construction Management, Tsinghua University

2016.09–2019 Second Bachelor's Degree in Economics (Dual-Degree Program), School of Economics and Management, Tsinghua University

Graduated with distinction; Excellent Graduate Award (top 1%).

Research Interests

Real estate and urban economics; household behavior and human capital; labor and inequality; environmental economics and climate adaptation; local public finance and political economy.

Journal Publications

1. **Corruption stereotype and the unintended consequences of an anti-corruption campaign: evidence from the real estate sector in China.** Hanming Fang and Rongjie Zhang. *Journal of Public Economics*, 249, 105474 (2025). *(co-corresponding author)*
2. **Unused housing in urban China and its carbon emission impact.** Hefan Zheng, Rongjie Zhang, Xinru Yin, and Jing Wu. *Nature Communications*, 16, 1985 (2025). *(co-corresponding author)*
3. **Caring about bequest, so caring for parents? Evidence from China's housing sector.** Jia He, Jing Wu, Qi Zhang, and Rongjie Zhang. *Real Estate Economics*, 52(6), 1446–1469 (2024). *(corresponding author)*
4. **The Aggregate and Distributional Impacts of Residence Policy Relaxation.** Rongsheng Tang, Yang Tang, and Rongjie Zhang. *Journal of Real Estate Finance and Economics*, 69(2), 343–376 (2024).
5. **Value of qualification to buy a house: Evidence from the housing purchase restriction policy in China.** Hefan Zheng, Rongjie Zhang, and Jing Wu. *Cities*, 135, 104197 (2023). *(corresponding author)*
6. **Land finance in China: Analysis and review.** Joseph Gyourko, Yang Shen, Jing Wu, and Rongjie Zhang. *China Economic Review*, 76, 101868 (2022). *(corresponding author)*
7. **Can Professional Football Players Adapt to Air Pollution? Evidence From China.** Yu Qin, Jing Wu, and Rongjie Zhang. *Journal of Sports Economics*, 23(3), 277–300 (2022). *(corresponding author)*
8. **Land Financing, Corporate Tax Subsidy, and Investment Attraction.** Rongjie Zhang, Weizeng Sun, Hao Li, and Jing Wu. *China Journal of Economics*, 8(4), 57–86 · In Chinese (2021).
9. **An Analysis of the Buyer Concentration in China's Residential Land Market: A Study Based on Big Data.** Jing Wu and Rongjie Zhang. *Journal of Jiangxi University of Finance and Economics*, 2020(1) · In Chinese (2020).

Working Papers

1. **Migration Restrictions and the Migrant-Native Wage Gap: The Roles of Wage Setting and Sorting.** Naijia Guo, Li Zhang, Ben Zou, and Rongjie Zhang. *Revise & resubmit, American Economic Review.*
2. **When Protection Hurts: Labor Market Consequences of Mandatory Heat Allowances in China.** Sumit Agarwal, Kam C. Chan, Nianhang Xu, Ruoming Yang, and Rongjie Zhang. *Revise & resubmit, Journal of Environmental Economics and Management.*
3. **Sex Ratios and Competitive Human Capital Investment: Evidence from Housing Prices and Educational Expenditures.** Shang-Jin Wei, Jing Wu, and Rongjie Zhang.
4. **Intra-household Bargaining and Fertility Decision-making: Evidence from Homeownership Structure and Housing Price Shocks in China.** Boyuan Huang, Jing Wu, and Rongjie Zhang.
5. **Elite Platforms or Big Fish? Sorting, Human Capital Accumulation, and Returns to Top University Admission.** Rongjie Zhang and Wenlan Qian.
6. **Defending the Coasts: Seawalls, Typhoons, and Adapting to Sea-Level Rise.** Yichun Fan, Yuqi Song, and Rongjie Zhang.

Teaching

2022–2023 Teaching Assistant, Real Estate Investment (graduate), Tsinghua University.

Tsinghua University Excellent Teaching Assistant Award, 2022 (ranked sixth university-wide in the evaluation).

2021–2023 Teaching Assistant, Real Estate Price Theories and Appraisal Techniques (undergraduate), Tsinghua University.

Journal Referee Service

Applied Economics Letters; Canadian Journal of Economics; China Economic Review; Cities; Economic Analysis and Policy; Economic Inquiry; Economic Modelling; Habitat International; Heliyon; International Journal of Strategic Property Management; Journal of Contemporary Accounting and Economics; Journal of Cleaner Production; Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization; Journal of Housing and the Built Environment; Journal of Housing Economics; Journal of Real Estate Finance and Economics; Journal of Regional Economics; Journal of Sports Economics; Real Estate Economics; Regional Science and Urban Economics; Review of Development Economics; Scientific Reports; Sustainable Development; Urban Studies.

Selected Conference and Seminar Presentations

2027 American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association Annual Conference (scheduled)

2026 Asian Bureau of Finance and Economic Research Annual Conference (Singapore); International Conference of China and Development Studies (Shanghai); China International Conference in Finance (Hong Kong); World Congress of Environmental and Resource Economics (Lisbon); Asian Real Estate Society–Global Chinese Real Estate Congress Joint International Real Estate Conference (Hangzhou); China Real Estate Academic Annual Conference (Xi'an)

2025 American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association Annual Conference (San Francisco); Asian Bureau of Finance and Economic Research Annual Conference (Singapore); Asian Economic Development Conference (Beijing); Asian Real Estate Society International Real Estate Conference (Melbourne); Global Chinese Real Estate Congress International Real Estate Conference (Beijing); China Real Estate Academic Annual Conference (Chizhou); Jinan University–Singapore Management University Conference on Urban and Regional Economics (Guangzhou)

2024 American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association Annual Conference (San Antonio); World Bank Land Conference (Washington, DC); Asian Economic Development Conference (Seoul); China Real Estate Academic Annual Conference (Wuhan); Renmin University of China–Global Labor Organization Annual Conference (Beijing); China Society of Urban Economy Annual Conference (Dali)

2023 Asian Bureau of Finance and Economic Research Annual Conference (Singapore); American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association Annual Conference (Cambridge, UK); Asian Real Estate Society–Global Chinese Real Estate Congress Joint International Real Estate Conference (Hong Kong); Massachusetts Institute of Technology Asia Real Estate Initiative Inaugural Symposium (Boston); China Real Estate Academic Annual Conference (Hangzhou); Jinan University–Singapore Management University Conference on Urban and Regional Economics (Guangzhou)

2022 Young Economist Society Annual Conference (Kunming)

2021 China Real Estate Academic Annual Conference (Shanghai); Symposium on Political Economics from Spatial Perspective (Zhuhai)

2020 Symposium on Chinese Economy (Beijing)

2018 China Real Estate Academic Annual Conference (Guangzhou)

Honors and Awards

2026 Research Excellence Award, Asia-Pacific Journal of Risk and Insurance

2025 Best Paper Award (First Prize), China Real Estate Academic Annual Conference

2024 Outstanding Ph.D. Dissertation, Tsinghua University (top 5%)

2024 Excellent Graduate, Tsinghua University (top 1%)

2024 Rising Academic Star Award, Tsinghua University

2024 Best Paper Award (First Prize), China Real Estate Academic Annual Conference

2023 Jiang Nanxiang Scholarship, Tsinghua University

2023 China National Scholarship

2023 Best Paper Award (Second Prize), China Real Estate Academic Annual Conference

2022 Excellent Teaching Assistant Award, Tsinghua University (ranked sixth university-wide)

2022 Best Paper Award, 684th Ph.D. Student Forum, Tsinghua University

2021 Best Paper Award (Second Prize), China Real Estate Academic Annual Conference

2020 Outstanding Student Cadre Benchmark, Tsinghua University

2019 Future Scholar Scholarship, Tsinghua University

2019 Excellent Graduate, Tsinghua University (top 1%)